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RUNS GALORE AND RISING STARS

Karnataka's **youth-driven triumph** ended a five-year title drought in a high-scoring Vijay Hazare season, where the T20 influence grew, and some stalwarts bid farewell to the game.

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Investing in the future often entails a long wait, but the gestation period wasn't too long for Karnataka as the faith reposed in its band of youngsters paid quick dividends.

The likes of R. Smaran, K.V. Aneesh, K.L. Shrijith and Abhilash Shetty rallied around their veteran skipper Mayank Agarwal to help Karnataka lift a record-equalling fifth Vijay Hazare Trophy crown and end its five-year title drought across formats.

The 21-year-old left-handed batter Smaran, playing his first season at the senior level, showcased exemplary tenacity and skill at No. 4, riding Karnataka out of



choppy waters in the semifinal and final to emerge as a bright all-format prospect for the team.

His 76-run contribution in the semifinal against defending champion Haryana was crucial in what eventually turned out to be a facile 238-run chase for Karnataka, while his sparkling century in the final set the tone for a massive 348-run total in a high-scoring final against Vidarbha in Vadodara.

Smaran was joined by fellow southpaws in helping Karnataka tide over precarious situations. Fresh from India's Test tour of Australia, Devdutt Padikkal cracked a ton in the quarterfinal against Baroda and